

Lighter than air

Airships and balloons filled with helium, a noble gas, are lighter than the surrounding air, so they float upwards. Helium is the second-lightest element after hydrogen. However, unlike hydrogen, which is highly flammable, helium is safe to use, although expensive.

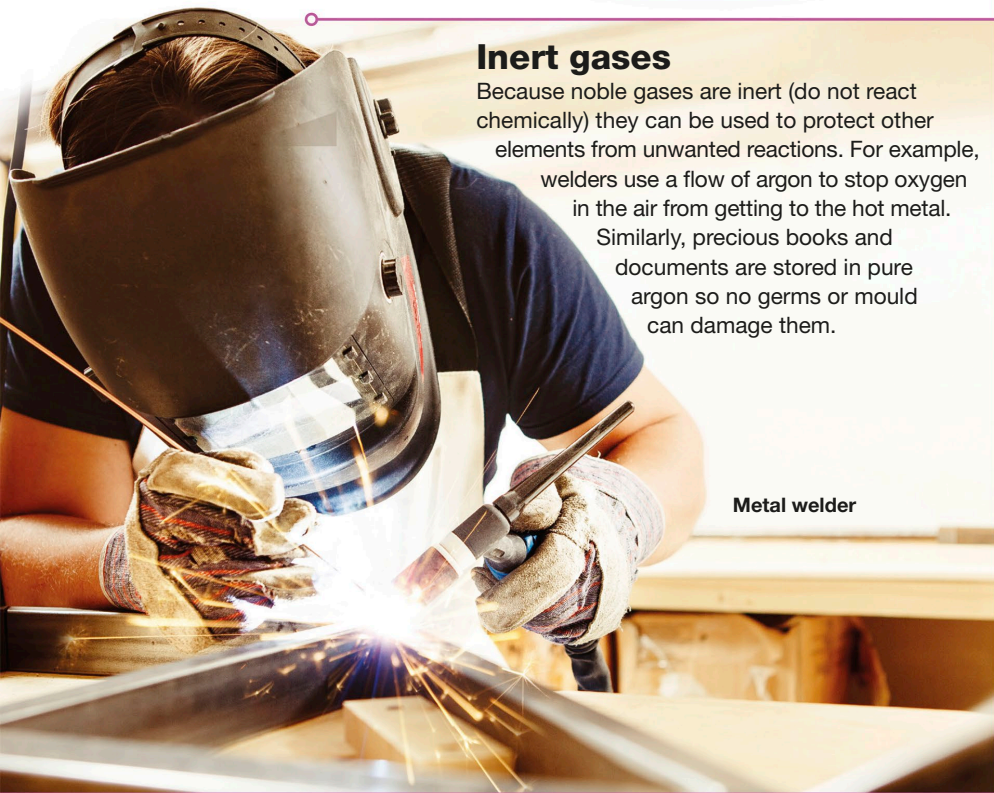


Propellor-powered
helium blimp

Inert gases

Because noble gases are inert (do not react chemically) they can be used to protect other elements from unwanted reactions. For example, welders use a flow of argon to stop oxygen in the air from getting to the hot metal.

Similarly, precious books and documents are stored in pure argon so no germs or mould can damage them.



Metal welder